

Suicidal Loyalty

When obedience becomes identity, and why middle managers carry out decisions they know are wrong

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Gad Saad calls it suicidal empathy when a virtue turns against the people who hold it. Business has its own version: loyalty that protects a decision at the expense of the company. Middle managers carry out orders they know to be wrong, and those who push back usually pay for it. AI will not fix this. It may give every executive team a perfect yes-man.

In the summer of 1628, a Swedish naval captain named Söfring Hansson had a bad feeling about the ship he was responsible for. The *Vasa* was the new pride of King Gustavus Adolphus, one of the most heavily armed warships in the world, built to announce that Sweden now ruled the Baltic. Hansson suspected she was unstable, and he asked Vice Admiral Klas Fleming to come and see for himself. Thirty sailors were lined up on deck and ordered to run together from one side of the ship to the other. After the third run the ship was rolling so badly that Fleming stopped the test before she capsized at the dock. According to later testimony from the ship's master, the admiral sighed that he wished the king were at home. The king was away fighting in Poland, sending letter after letter demanding that the ship be put to sea as soon as possible. Fleming never passed his concern up the line.

On August 10, the *Vasa* set out on her maiden voyage with her gunports open for a ceremonial salute. The first gust of wind heeled her over, the second pushed the lower gunports under water, and after about 1,300 meters the king's showpiece lay on the bottom of Stockholm harbor in front of a crowd of thousands. Some 30 people drowned. At the inquiry that followed, everyone swore he had done his duty. Asked why the ship sank, one of the builders replied that only God knew. The king had personally approved the dimensions and the armament, so no guilty party could be found, and the blame quietly settled on the chief shipwright, who had died the previous year and could not defend himself.

What makes Fleming interesting is that he was neither a fool nor a coward. He was born in Finland, then the eastern half of the Swedish realm, and he is remembered as one of the ablest administrators the Swedish navy ever had. He died commanding the fleet in battle against Denmark in 1644. In the summer of 1628 he lacked something other than courage or competence. He could not bring himself to set the king's wishes against the king's interests, even though he had just watched the two collide on deck. He was loyal to the order rather than to the ship.

A virtue that turns on its owner

Suicidal empathy has become one of the political catchphrases of 2026, largely thanks to Gad Saad, a Canadian marketing professor whose book of that name appeared in May. Saad argues that empathy, one of our noblest traits, can become miscalibrated and start working against the very people who hold it. I will not take sides on the book's political conclusions here. The underlying structure, however, will be familiar to anyone who has run an organization. A virtue that works well at small scale becomes harmful at large scale, and it is hard to name the problem because nobody wants to be the person who criticizes a virtue.

In business, that virtue is loyalty. Loyal people deliver what was agreed, defend team decisions in public and do not jump to a competitor at the first setback. No company would survive a month without them. The trouble starts when the object of loyalty shifts without anyone noticing. Loyalty to the company and its purpose turns into loyalty to a boss, a decision or one's own position, and at that point good people fall silent about exactly the thing the company most needs to hear. I call this suicidal loyalty.

The economist Albert Hirschman argued in *Exit, Voice, and Loyalty* in 1970 that loyalty keeps people from leaving and makes them speak up when things go wrong. The loyal member does not walk out. He stays and demands repair. That is the healthy form of loyalty, and it is the one every executive says he wants. What happened on the deck of the *Vasa*, and what happens in a great many conference rooms today, is a different form. People stay and keep quiet, preserving the appearance of loyalty while giving up its substance.

Two hats

On the evening of January 27, 1986, engineers at Morton Thiokol in Utah tried to convince NASA not to launch the space shuttle *Challenger* the next morning. The forecast called for freezing temperatures, and the rubber O-rings sealing the joints of the solid rocket boosters grew stiff in the cold. Thiokol's management initially sided with its engineers and recommended a delay. NASA's program managers on the phone did not like the recommendation, and Thiokol's executives asked for a recess to talk among themselves. The company had a major NASA contract coming up for renewal.

During the recess, senior vice president Jerry Mason polled the room. Three executives voted to launch. The last to speak was Bob Lund, vice president of engineering, the man who represented both management and the engineers. Brian Russell, an engineer who was present, has recalled that Lund hesitated for a long time, until Mason told him it was time to take off his engineering hat and put on his management hat. Lund changed hats. The next morning, launch control announced that the technical community was in consensus. *Challenger* broke apart 73 seconds after liftoff, killing all seven astronauts on board.

Lund's moment captures the position of middle management better than any org chart. He knew what the data said and he knew his engineers, but he also knew what was expected of him. Nobody appoints a middle manager for the purpose of endorsing decisions from above, yet in practice the job rests on exactly that. Mason's metaphor reveals an assumption that is more common than most executives admit, namely that leadership and truth are separate roles and that one has to choose between them.

Roger Boisjoly, the engineer who had warned about the O-rings in a memo six months be-

fore the accident, testified before the presidential commission. Afterwards he was shunned by colleagues and managers, taken off space work and eventually left the company. By his own account the only public gesture of support came from astronaut Sally Ride, who hugged him after his testimony. Every engineer who followed his story learned something from it, though probably not the lesson NASA had in mind.

Silence is a calculation

Organizational researchers have a name for this: organizational silence. In a 2003 study, Frances Milliken, Elizabeth Morrison and Patricia Hewlin of New York University interviewed 40 experienced employees. Eighty-five percent said they had been in situations where they did not raise an issue they considered important with their boss. The most common reason was fear of being labeled a troublemaker and damaging valued relationships. The topics people most often kept to themselves were management's own behavior and the direction of the company, which are precisely the topics that matter most.

In 2011, James Detert of Cornell and Amy Edmondson of Harvard described a set of unwritten rules that people follow at work without thinking about them. Don't embarrass the boss in front of others. Don't go over the boss's head. Don't speak up unless you have solid data and a finished solution. American readers will recognize the last one as a management slogan: *don't bring me problems, bring me solutions*. Each rule sounds sensible on its own, but together they form a filter that stops useful information before anyone says it out loud. The solutions rule is the most treacherous, because the person with the worst news rarely has a solution. If he did, the news would not be that bad.

The caution is not paranoia. In a 2012 study of restaurant managers, Ethan Burriss of the University of Texas found that bosses rated employees who challenged current practices as weaker performers than those who supported them. In a follow-up experiment the challengers were also seen as less loyal. In other words, the employee who tries to save the company from a bad decision gets branded disloyal for his trouble. Elizabeth McClean and colleagues found in 2018 that suggesting improvements can raise a person's standing in a group, but in their data the payoff went to men only. Warning that something should be stopped raised nobody's standing at all, regardless of gender. Leslie John's team at Harvard Business School showed in 11 experiments that people dislike the bearer of bad news even when the messenger has nothing to do with it.

None of this is new. Plutarch tells of Tigranes the Great, king of Armenia, who had the first messenger reporting the approach of a Roman army beheaded. After that nobody dared bring him information, and he went to war blind. Modern executives do not behead anyone, but their organizations learn the same lesson in subtler ways. In the Ethics & Compliance Initiative's 2023 global survey, nearly half of the employees who reported misconduct said they had experienced some form of retaliation. When speaking up costs you personally and immediately, while silence costs everyone collectively and later, silence is a rational response to incentives rather than a character flaw.

The middle manager's double bind

Middle managers have it worse than anyone, because they are both the audience and the messenger. When a corporate decision comes down, their job is to take it to their teams and make it work. Most do so conscientiously, and that is exactly where the trap lies. Once a manager has stood in front of her team and argued for a decision, she owns it, even though she had no part in making it. If the decision turns out badly, admitting it means admitting she led her own people in the wrong direction. At this point suicidal empathy and suicidal loyalty run on the same mechanism, because admitting the mistake threatens a person's self-image and not merely a forecast.

Barry Staw of Northwestern showed as early as 1976 that decision makers pour the most additional money into a losing venture when they are personally responsible for the original decision. The effect is known as escalation of commitment, and anyone who has sat through a capital project review has seen it. A middle manager who has sold a decision downward has made it personal. She defends it upward because she has already defended it downward, and she hears her team's doubts with the ears of someone who has already taken a position.

Ego is not only a problem for subordinates. Nathanael Fast, Ethan Burris and Caroline Bartel found in 2014 that managers who doubted their own managerial competence asked their people for fewer ideas, judged those who spoke up more harshly and acted on suggestions less often. In an experiment they showed that the driver was ego defensiveness. An insecure boss avoids listening because listening reminds him of what he does not know. The title of their paper puts it well, since such a boss is managing to stay in the dark.

Sometimes silence is requested outright. In 1975 a 24-year-old Kodak engineer named Steve Sasson built the world's first digital camera, a device the size of a toaster that took 23 seconds to record a black-and-white image onto a cassette tape. When he demonstrated it to company executives, nobody asked how it worked. They asked why anyone would want to look at photographs on a television set, and the reaction Sasson remembers best was that the device was cute but that he should not tell anyone about it. Kodak patented the invention and kept developing the technology in its labs, but film was the company's cash machine and nobody wanted to threaten it. Kodak filed for bankruptcy protection in 2012. Sasson's experience is a reminder that silence can also be ordered from the top, politely and with a smile.

Loyalty does not pay the way it is supposed to, either. Matthew Stanley and colleagues at Duke asked roughly 1,400 managers whom they would assign unpaid extra work during a tight budget period. Employees described as loyal got more of it, because managers assumed loyal people were willing to sacrifice. In follow-up studies, workers who agreed to be exploited earned a stronger reputation for loyalty as a result. Loyalty attracts the extra load, carrying the load strengthens the reputation for loyalty, and the assumption quietly hardens that this person will not say no.

I have sat on both sides of the table, as a plant manager carrying decisions from above to the shop floor and as an executive with plant managers reporting to me. From the upper seat, silence is surprisingly hard to hear, because it looks exactly like agreement. A meeting where nobody objects feels like a good meeting. Only months later does it become clear whether the room was in consensus or whether everyone had separately calculated that it did not pay to go first.

The clock in the conference room

In large corporate disasters the same pattern repeats with such regularity that it may as well be a law. The two 737 MAX crashes in 2018 and 2019 killed 346 people. The 2020 report of the House Transportation Committee named a culture of concealment as one of the causes. According to an internal Boeing survey provided to the committee, 39 percent of respondents felt undue pressure and 29 percent worried about the consequences of reporting it. The chair of the aviation subcommittee described how senior management had installed countdown clocks in conference rooms. The message to employees was clear, and it was not about safety.

At Volkswagen the fear was even more visible. Former executives interviewed by Reuters described a culture under CEO Martin Winterkorn in which bad news was not carried upward and edicts from the top were not debated. The German tabloid *Bild* reported that engineers did not dare tell Winterkorn that his public 2012 pledge to cut the group's carbon dioxide emissions by 30 percent by 2015 would be hard to meet. After the emissions cheating came to light, Bernd Osterloh, the employees' representative on the supervisory board, wrote to staff that the company needed a culture in which problems are not hidden and in which people may argue with their superiors about the best way forward. The demand sounds so obvious that it is telling it had to be put in writing at all.

At Wells Fargo, aggressive sales targets led to roughly two million accounts opened without customers' knowledge between 2011 and 2015. The bank fired 5,300 employees. Meanwhile, a number of former employees said they had been fired shortly after calling the company's own ethics hotline. The CEO assured the Senate that every team member is encouraged to raise his or her hand. Some had, and their hands had been noted.

These cases share a feature that echoes the *Vasa* inquiry, which is that the guilty party is always found further down. In Stockholm the blame fell on a dead shipwright. Volkswagen's new leadership initially spoke of a few developers who had interfered with engine software, and at Wells Fargo thousands of branch employees lost their jobs before the board clawed back pay from the top executives. Middle managers learn from this too. If a decision goes wrong, the blame flows downhill, and if they oppose it, the consequences arrive at once. Loyalty upward looks like the only safe choice, even though in the end it protects nobody.

Even in the Nordics

American readers may assume that Nordic workplaces have solved this. Finland is among the lowest power-distance cultures in the world, a country where employees address the CEO by first name and where the managing director may well be seen queuing in the company canteen. Survey data support that picture only partly. In a 2018 national survey, 85 percent of Finnish employees said they dared to tell their boss when they disagreed. In the same survey, more than a third felt that their boss withheld information, and nearly a third found it uncomfortable to propose new ideas in public. In a survey commissioned this summer by the HR services firm SD Worx, only 19 percent of Finns said they had ever felt safe discussing their own ability to cope at work with their manager.

The numbers do not contradict each other. Finns will speak their minds about the coffee machine and the shift roster. In the Milliken study, people were most often silent about management's conduct and the company's direction, and the same line seems to run through Finnish

workplaces. Silence starts where the issue touches the boss's own decision or the employee's own limits. The good Finnish worker does not complain, and he is rewarded for it. The same virtue makes him dangerously quiet at the very moment he should speak.

A Finnish example from the nuclear industry shows how this plays out on a construction site. Olkiluoto 3, the country's newest reactor, became one of the most delayed construction projects in Europe. Early on, the concrete mix for the reactor's base slab was altered in the middle of the pour and no longer met the specification, and the licensee informed the regulator about half a year later. The investigation launched by the Finnish nuclear regulator in 2006 concluded that the network of companies involved did not share an understanding of how the construction phase affects nuclear safety. Researchers later described how subcontractors had fallen back on practices from other industries whenever work did not go as planned. Schedule pressure and long subcontracting chains are a familiar combination in which stopping always feels more expensive than carrying on, and it shows in how long it takes for news from the end of the chain to reach the customer.

AI, the perfect yes-man

Artificial intelligence is now expected to fix the flow of information in organizations. In my previous essay, *Who Gets to See the Map?*, I wrote about how data could travel through a company without being filtered by intermediate layers. Technology does not solve the silence problem, however, and the latest research suggests it may make it worse. In March, a Stanford team led by Myra Cheng published a study in *Science* examining 11 leading large language models. The models affirmed users' actions and views about 50 percent more often than humans did in the same situations, including when users described deceptive or harmful behavior. In experiments with some 2,400 participants, a single conversation with a sycophantic model made people more convinced they were right and less willing to repair the situation. Participants rated the flattering models as more trustworthy and wanted to use them again. This is exactly the profile of the middle manager few executives have ever regarded as a problem, the one who is pleasant, fast and always in agreement.

A CEO who stress-tests his strategy with an AI assistant has therefore hired a deputy who never tires and never fears being fired, yet is as agreeable as the most frightened employee in the building. The machine does not flatter out of fear but because it was trained on answers that people liked. The outcome is the same as on the deck of the *Vasa*, since the decision maker hears what he wants to hear and mistakes it for information.

At the same time, companies are cutting middle management in the name of AI. Amazon announced 14,000 corporate job cuts in October 2025, explicitly citing the removal of organizational layers, and Gartner has predicted that by the end of 2026 one in five organizations will use AI to flatten its structure and eliminate more than half of its middle-management positions. In Korn Ferry's survey of more than 15,000 professionals, 41 percent said their employer had cut management layers and 37 percent said they felt directionless as a result. According to Gallup, manager engagement fell further in 2024 than that of any other group. Removing middle managers does not remove silence. In the middle of a layoff wave, the manager who survives, now perhaps with 25 direct reports instead of seven, thinks harder than ever before about whether bad news is worth sending upward.

What aviation learned

The best antidote comes from an industry in which silence has cost lives. In December 1978, a United Airlines DC-8 circled Portland, Oregon, for about an hour while the crew dealt with a landing gear problem. The flight engineer repeatedly told the captain about the fuel state, but the captain stayed focused on the gear and on preparing for an emergency landing. All four engines flamed out, and the plane came down in a wooded suburb. Ten people died. The National Transportation Safety Board listed as a contributing cause the failure of the other two crew members either to grasp how critical the fuel situation was or to get their concern across to the captain. The information was in the cockpit the entire time, it simply never made it across the flight deck.

United went on to create the airline industry's first program of what became known as crew resource management. The training works in two directions. First officers and flight engineers are taught to state their concerns plainly and to repeat them if they are not heard, rather than hinting. Captains are taught to ask for challenges and to treat them as part of the job rather than as a threat to their authority. The hierarchy survived, and the captain still decides. What changed is what is expected of the captain before the decision.

Business has similar tools, but they are rarely used in earnest. The psychologist Gary Klein developed the premortem, in which a team imagines that a project has already failed and writes down why. It works because it turns warning into an assignment that everyone is obliged to complete. Jeff Bezos described the principle of *disagree and commit* in his 2016 letter to Amazon shareholders, in which people are expected to voice disagreement openly and then commit to the decision. The principle only works if the disagreement is recorded and revisited when the results come in. Otherwise it becomes a polite way of telling people to be quiet. A third tool follows from Staw's research: the decision to continue a project should not be made by the same person who decided to start it.

A ship on paper

The *Vasa* story has an epilogue. Within about 20 years of the sinking, Sweden stopped relying on Dutch shipwrights and turned to English methods. The reasons were many, but the difference between the two traditions is instructive for any leader. The Dutch built ships from experience and a practiced eye, without drawings. The English put the design on paper and built a scale model that could be examined with the customer before the keel was ever laid. Once the ship was on the table, anyone could point at it. Doubt stopped being a subordinate's private feeling and became a shared observation that took no courage to voice.

In the age of AI, a leader's job is to build that kind of table into the organization. Data can be visible to everyone, but what matters is whether people may draw unwelcome conclusions from it out loud, and what happens to them afterwards. There is no point in trying to reduce loyalty, because no organization holds together without it. Its object, however, deserves regular inspection. Loyalty to the company's purpose sometimes requires disloyalty to a particular decision, and making that safe is the leader's job. Fleming stopped the test because he feared the ship would capsize at the dock, when what he should have stopped was the voyage.

Questions for your own organization

- When did someone last say out loud in your executive team that a decision already made should be reversed? What happened to that person afterwards?
- Who last stopped a project, and were they thanked as visibly as the person who started it?
- In performance reviews, are managers who push back rated as stronger or as more difficult than those who go along?
- Is the decision to continue a project made by the same person who decided to launch it?
- How many unfinished projects keep running because stopping them would embarrass someone?
- What happens to people who report problems, and does anyone track it?
- Does your leadership team ask its AI tools for counterarguments or for confirmation?
- As layers are removed, who now receives the bad news?

Worth considering

- **Ask first.** Invite objections before you state your own view, because once the boss has spoken, few people argue.
- **Run a premortem.** Review major decisions by imagining they have already failed, and record the reasons the team comes up with.
- **Separate the continuation decision.** Let someone other than the project's sponsor decide whether it goes on.
- **Record dissent.** When someone disagrees but commits anyway, write down the warning and return to it when the results arrive.
- **Reward the person who stops things.** Publicly credit whoever killed a bad project as visibly as whoever launched a good one.
- **Protect the messenger.** Follow how the careers and ratings of people who raised problems develop, and step in yourself if the trend is wrong.
- **Make the machine argue back.** When you test a decision with AI, ask it first for the strongest case against your own position.
- **Check what you are loyal to.** Ask yourself whether you are defending the company or your own earlier decision.

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